

TEN STRATEGIES FOR DEALING WITH DIFFICULTY

TEXT: Psalms 77:11-20

INTRO: The author of this Psalm is Asaph, who is described in Scripture as the son of Berechiah of the Gershonite family and was appointed by David and later by Solomon to be over the service of song. In this Scripture, Asaph is probably meditating on the direction the music should take for the upcoming services and in this deliberation he begins to think of God's mighty power in helping Israel to negotiate the difficulty of the Red Sea passage. He then begins to write to the chief musician and say's ... (Read text again)

The Red Sea passage is one of the great miracles of the Bible. Someone said that it was not a miracle at all because the Red Sea was only a very small body of water that could have easily been forded by a child. IF that were so, this instance becomes an even greater miracle because God drowned the host of the Egyptians in the Red Sea!

This miracle is laid out before us in the fourteenth chapter of Exodus. The Israelites have been freed from 400 years of slavery in Egypt and they march triumphantly out of the land. When the reality of what the burden the Israelites have been carrying for the Egyptian economy begins to settle in on the Egyptians they change their minds and pursue Israel. Now the Israelites face the dilemma of the Red Sea in front of them and Pharaoh's army behind them! They are trapped! There is no way out! Have you ever been there?

In your marriage

On your job

With your children

In your finances

In your spiritual walk

The feeling of being trapped is hopelessness; there is no way out! But wait a minute, there is still a thing called a miracle!

God still performs miracles! The day of miracles is not over because there never was a day of miracles; this is a God of miracles! It is Gods nature to do a miracle! He is more apt to do a miracle than not to do one!

Charles Spurgeon said, "The Lord will make a way for you where no foot has been before. That which, like a sea, threatens to drown you, shall be a highway for your escape."

Being trapped and feeling hopeless calls for a miracle! Over the next few weeks I want us to look at this instance of the Red Sea passage and take from it at least ten lessons! The ten strategies we will be considering are as follows:
God means for you to be where you are!

Be more concerned for God's glory than for your relief!

Acknowledge your enemy but keep your eyes on the Lord!

Pray!

Give God time to work!

When unsure, just take the next logical step by faith!

Envision God' enveloping presence!

Trust God to deliver in His own unique way!

View your current crisis as a faith builder for the future!

Don't forget to praise Him!

Asaph records his thoughts in Psalm 77 where,

When we need a miracle we expect God to build it, decorate it and deliver it to us in a nice neat carefully wrapped package but listen very carefully to the words of Asaph in verses 19 & 20 “_____” In this passage Asaph say’s that God wrought His miracle for Israel THROUGH Moses and Aaron. Very few times will you receive a miracle without putting forth some effort on your own! God is willing to make a miracle for your life but you we must be obedient in order for the thing to be brought forth in our life!

In the story of the Red Sea, Asaph found strength to overcome his own dilemma! Asaph? The Choir Director with a dilemma? Listen to what he say’s in the first 11 verses...

In the day of trouble I sought the lord!
I experienced trouble I could not control!
I complained to God!
My spirit was overwhelmed!
I am so troubled I cannot speak!
Will God ever hear me again?
Will God ignore me forever?
Will He ever be good to me again?
Will He ever show me mercy again?
Will His promises be good?
Will He be gracious?
Is God so angry that He fails to show me mercy?

Then He say’s Vs. 10-20 “_____”

Just think of the miracle he speaks of in verses 19 and 20:
The winds blew the sea split!
Te waters congealed into towering walls!
The Israelites passed through on dry ground!

This happened not for the entertainment value of the experience, but to prove to the Israelites and to us in earth shaking, history-making fashion that; even when we are most anxious and distressed, God will make a way when there seems to be no way!

Exodus 14 provides a biblical model to process difficulties by faith, in the light of God's almighty:

Presence!

Providence!

Promise!

Power!

The Red Sea may roll before us; the desert may entrap us; the enemy may press on our heels. The past may seem implausible; the future impossible; but God works in ways we cannot see. He will make a way of escape for His children! Isaiah 43:19 “___”
1 Cor. 10:13 “___” Col. 4:2-3 “___” Is. 11:15-16 “___”

Remember, no sea is deeper than the ocean of His love. There is no army stronger than His hosts, no force greater than His throne of grace, no enemy who can overcome His direct and indirect work in our lives. The reality of the Red Sea, in a word, is this: God will always make a way for His tired, yet trusting, children, even if He must split the sea to do it.

RED SEA

RULE I

I. STRATEGY # 1: REALIZE, GOD MEANS FOR US TO BE WHERE WE ARE!

Exodus 14:1-4 (NKJV) *“Now the LORD spoke to Moses, saying:2 “Speak to the children of Israel, that they turn and camp before Pi Hahiroth, between Migdol and the sea, opposite Baal Zephon; you shall camp before it by the sea.3 “For Pharaoh will say of the children of Israel, ‘They are bewildered by the land; the wilderness has closed them in.’4 “Then I will harden Pharaoh’s heart, so that he will pursue them; and I will gain honor over Pharaoh and over all his army, that the Egyptians may know that I am the LORD.” And they did so.”*

The Lord is so specific with Moses that He actually tells him to turn back and camp at a specific place. What I am about to say will sound somewhat sacrilegious but I do not mean it that way! God’s instructions very seldom make logical sense. And for that reason, those who pursue His will understand that they must receive His instructions with a spiritual mind, rather than a logical mind.

The place where they camped really hemmed them in! The sea was before them, Pharaoh's hosts behind them, and the mountains around them. And all this, at Gods instruction!

Three things for us to remember when we face difficulty:

- We are able to control the outcome of some difficulties!
- Some circumstances are beyond our control!
- Whether or not we have any control, God will guide every circumstance to a satisfactory conclusion, if we will trust and obey Him!

When we face difficulty it is easy for us to allow ourselves to begin to explore the world of worry! Someone described worry

like this: *"Worry is the trickle of fear that meanders through the mind, cutting a channel into that which all other thoughts flow."*

John R. Rice said, *"Worry is putting question marks where God has put Periods."*

Bishop Fulton J. Sheen called worry, *"A form of atheism, for it portrays a lack of faith and trust in God."*

But for some of us, worry seems as inherent as breathing. Most of us do not feel that we have done our due diligence until we have worried sufficiently in difficult times. Worry is the enemy of faith! Look at what the Jesus had to say about worry.

Matthew 6:25-34 (CEV) ***"I tell you not to worry about your life. Don't worry about having something to eat, drink, or wear. Isn't life more than food or clothing? 26 Look at the birds in the sky! They don't plant or harvest. They don't even store grain in barns. Yet your Father in heaven takes care of them. Aren't you worth more than birds? 27 Can worry make you live longer? 28 Why worry about clothes? Look how the wild flowers grow. They don't work hard to make their clothes. 29 But I tell you that Solomon with all his wealth wasn't as well clothed as one of them. 30 God gives such beauty to everything that grows in the fields, even though it is here today and thrown into a fire tomorrow. He will surely do even more for you! Why do you have such little faith? 31 Don't worry and ask yourselves, "Will we have anything to eat? Will we have anything to drink? Will we have any clothes to wear?" 32 Only people who don't know God are always worrying about such things. Your Father in heaven knows that you need all of these. 33 But more than anything else, put God's work first and do what he wants. Then the other things will be yours as well. 34 Don't worry about tomorrow. It will take care of itself. You have enough to worry about today."***

How can we keep from worrying when?

- Our outgo exceeds our income and it appears our upkeep

is going to be our downfall?

- The creditors are calling?
- Our financial portfolio is collapsing?
- When we are terminated from a job we intended to retire from?
- When a loved one is diagnosed with an incurable disease?
- When a child is living in a rebellious state, doing who knows what with who knows who? (Fox News: After the New Orleans flood a reporter interviewed a group of gothic teens who ran a tattoo parlor on Bourbon Street. They were walking out of the city; one girl asked to use the reporter's cell phone and when the person on the other end answered she said, "*Daddy, can you come get me?*" As it turned out, she was a Pastor's daughter from Ohio. Daddy had probably been praying, "*Lord whatever it takes...*")

How could Moses and Aaron keep from worrying when the Red Sea was facing them? The mountains were beside them? The soldiers of Egypt were bearing down on them with swords drawn?

What helped create faith in a moment of terror was the fact that they knew Jehovah delivered them from Egypt and that it was His will for them to go to Canaan! Moses determined that they were where they were not by their own will, but according to the will of God!

When we determine that we are where we are by the will of God, we should begin converting our worries into prayers and our fears into faith. God will never send you to a place without furnishing the grace to do His will while maintaining your sanity and integrity!

In the story of the Red Sea the Israelites followed the pillar of cloud and fire as carefully as possible; they were no doubt thrilled with their new freedom and were full of excitement

about the future. They were leaving 400 years of slavery behind them! They were marching toward:

- A new country where they would experience freedom for the first time!
- A new opportunity for upward mobility!
- A new home, one of their choosing!

Yet as they followed Him, God deliberately led them into a cul-de-sac between hostile hills, to the edge of a sea too deep to be forded and too wide to be crossed. The unmistakable indication of Exodus 14:1-4 is that the Lord took responsibility for leading them into peril. He gave them specific, step-by-step instructions, leading them down a route to apparent ruin: ***“Turn and camp; camp there; there, before the entrapping sea; yes, right there in that impossible place.”***

Please understand that God was not being disingenuous to Israel:

- He was about to deal with Israel’s enemies once and for all!
- He was about to allow them to see Him in a way they had never seen Him before!
- He was about to provide them with weapons to protect themselves, during the forty plus years of wilderness wandering!

The Lord occasionally does the same with us, testing our faith, leading us into hardship, teaching us wisdom, showing us His ways. Our first reaction may be a surge of panic and a sense of alarm, but we must learn to:

- Make sure we are in His will!
- Make sure we have not sinned!
- Express faith rather than fear!

We must be patient while He brings the components necessary for our deliverance together! We must speak the Word rather than focusing on the circumstances!

Consider these men and women who, through no fault of their own, found themselves inundated with disabling difficulties while trying to follow God:

- Hagar, a single mom, forced into the desert with her boy, to die of thirst!
- Joseph, wanting to fulfill divine dreams, was seized, stripped, sold as a slave, and imprisoned in Egypt!
- Moses was caught between the splendors of Egyptian royalty and thankless affliction with God's people!
- David was anointed by Samuel and then pursued by Saul and Israelite troops!
- Hezekiah, seeking revival, was trapped by the most powerful army on earth, who were bent on annihilating him and his people!
- The Lord's disciples sailed at His command on Galilee only to face a terror-filled night of storms and waves!
- The Son of man Himself fulfilling the Father's will, was nailed fast to a wooden cross and left to hang by His hands and feet until dead!
- The apostles, trying to preach this Crucified One, were horsewhipped!

The leader of that apostolic band later wrote, 1 Peter 4:12 (NKJV) ***"Beloved, do not think it strange concerning the fiery trial which is to try you, as though some strange thing happened to you;"*** Jesus said, in John 16:33-34 (NKJV) ***"These things I have spoken to you, that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world."*** The Psalmist said, Psalms (NKJV) Psalm 37:23-24 ***"The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD, And He delights in his way. 24 Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down; For the LORD upholds him with His hand."*** This is like a father following closely behind his child who is learning to ride a bicycle; he allows the child to ride but is determined not to allow him to get hurt.

God allows our faith to be tried, and He permits troubles to crowd into our lives. Sometimes they seem more than we can

bear, but Christ will help us bear them. The first step toward parted waters is to frequently remind ourselves, that the Lord has either put us in this difficult place, or has allowed us to be there for reasons perhaps only He knows!

Remember; the same God who led you in will lead you out; our difficulties may lock us in but they cannot lock our Lord out! Do you remember Daniel? The three Hebrew Children? Do you remember Paul's shipwreck? Do you remember John's plight on the island of Patmos?

God will never allow you to be placed where His grace cannot go! God will never show up too late or with too little, but He is always on time with more than enough!

There are no mistakes in God's plan; Jesus does all things well. A. W Tozer said, *"To the child of God, there is no such thing as an accident. He travels an appointed way... Accidents may indeed appear to befall him and misfortune stalk his way; but these evils will be so in appearance only and will seem evils only because we cannot read the secret Script of God's hidden providence."*

During a very difficult time South African Pastor Andrew Murray made the following statement:

- *He brought me here; it is by His will that I am in this strait place: in that fact I will rest!*
- *He will keep me here in His love, and give me grace to behave as His child!*
- *He will make the trial a blessing, teaching me the lessons He intends me to learn, and working in me the grace He means to bestow!*
- *In His good time He can bring me out again, how and when only He knows!*

SONG: "I'll go where you want me to go."

II. STRATEGY #2: BE MORE CONCERNED FOR GODS GLORY THAN FOR OUR RELIEF!

As we begin to deal with the temptation of seeking our relief above everything else, let me just say that this is a very natural reaction to difficult circumstances. At the same time we must be aware that the natural mind is the enemy of faith and of Gods will. When we encounter difficult times we must always remember that God is using this to set us up for victory while setting the enemy up for defeat.

In Scripture, God often allowed His people to endure hardship while he was collecting their enemies for a major disaster! Such is the case here at the Red Sea! Notice Exodus 14:3-4, (KJV)
“For Pharaoh will say of the children of Israel, They are entangled in the land, the wilderness hath shut them in. 4 And I will harden Pharaoh’s heart, that he shall follow after them; and I will be honored upon Pharaoh, and upon all his host; that the Egyptians may know that I am the LORD. And they did so.”

When we encounter impossible odds we should always ask ourselves, “What is God up to in this situation?” When we come upon a difficult crisis we must always remember that if we operate in faith rather than fear God will ultimately reveal His:

- Divine grace!
- Divine sufficiency!
- Divine will!

Every trial is meant to enable the believer to preserve the balance of the Christian life and to bring glory to God in the most difficult of times.

In difficult times we are often perplexed because the trial seems to be without rhyme or reason and we cannot find the answers to our questions. This is mostly because we are asking the wrong questions. We ask questions like;

- How did I get into this mess?
- Why did this happen to me?
- How quickly can I solve this problem?

These are natural questions, but they may be the wrong ones to ask. The children of Israel made this mistake, Exodus 14:10-12 (CEV) ***“When the Israelites saw the king coming with his army, they were frightened and begged the LORD for help. 11 They also complained to Moses, “Wasn’t there enough room in Egypt to bury us? Is that why you brought us out here to die in the desert? Why did you bring us out of Egypt anyway? 12 While we were there, didn’t we tell you to leave us alone? We had rather be slaves in Egypt than die in this desert!”***

There is a better approach, one that results in an entirely new way of looking at difficulties; one that puts our problems into a different context and creates a new paradigm for dealing with tough situations.

(PLACE THE MAP ON THE SCREEN)

Israel was befuddled by the sight of the Red Sea on two sides, the mountains on the other, and Pharaoh’s army closing in from behind! Moses and Aaron could have joined in the negativity of the crowd but they decided to trust God and find out what His plan was for their situation. Exodus 14:13-14 (CEV) ***“But Moses answered, “Don’t be afraid! Be brave, and you will see the LORD save you today. These Egyptians will never bother you again. 14 The LORD will fight for you, and you won’t have to do a thing.”***

The next time we are overwhelmed, instead of asking, *“How can I get out of this mess?”* We should try asking, *“How can God be glorified in this situation?”* Our perspective is entirely changed by the spiritual realities behind this approach. Notice the way this develops in Exodus 14:3-4 (CEV). With regard to where they were to camp, God said to Moses, (CEV) ***“The king will think they were afraid to cross the desert and that they are wandering around, trying to find another way to leave the***

country. 4 I will make the king stubborn again, and he will try to catch you. Then I will destroy him and his army. People everywhere will praise me for my victory, and the Egyptians will know that I really am the LORD. The Israelites obeyed the LORD and camped where he told them.

God deliberately orchestrated the impending attack of Egypt's army upon the Israelites here at the Red Sea! What is God thinking? He is about to demonstrate to Israel and the rest of the world the power He wields over His enemies and the elements. The New International version puts it like this, "**I will gain glory for myself through Pharaoh and his army.**"

(TAKE THE MAP DOWN)

On that dramatic evening:

- God's glory was revealed while the spray of the Red Sea was being felt by His people who appeared to be hopelessly trapped!
- The water of the mighty sea was divided by a strong east wind!
- The wind created liquid walls from that which only hours before appeared to be a formidable foe!
- The ocean floor began to appear as dry land!

All this was accomplished as the wide-eyed Israelites became aware of the power of the God they would follow through forty plus years of wilderness wandering.

The miracle of the Red Sea was revealed in the most difficult of circumstances. This miracle became the substance of their songs and stories for many generations. Psalm 136:10-16 (CEV) "**God struck down the first-born in every Egyptian family. God's love never fails. 11 He rescued Israel from Egypt. God's love never fails. 12 God used his great strength and his powerful arm. God's love never fails. 13 He split the Red Sea apart. God's love never fails. 14 The Lord brought Israel safely through the sea. God's love never fails. 15 He destroyed the Egyptian king and his army there. God's love never fails. 16**

The Lord led his people through the desert. God's love never fails."

When facing difficulty we should attempt to maintain the attitude of J. Hudson Taylor who said, *"I know He tries me only to increase my faith, and that is all in love. If His will is glorified I am content."*

Jesus himself practiced this strategy for dealing with difficulty while dealing with a man who was born blind. John 9:1-2 (CEV) His disciples asked, ***"Teacher, why was this man born blind? Was it because he or his parents sinned?"*** Listen to how Jesus answers their questions. John 9:3 (CEV) ***"No, it wasn't!" Jesus answered. "But because of his blindness, you will see God work a miracle for him."***

In John chapter 11, Jesus' best friends are in the process of encountering a crisis. Lazarus is very ill, Mary and Martha send word for Jesus to come and heal him. Listen to the words of Jesus upon hearing of his friend's illness. John 11:4 (CEV) ***"His sickness won't end in death. It will bring glory to God and his Son."***

Jesus waits two day's before responding and by the time he arrived, Lazarus is dead. John 11:14 (CEV) ***"Then Jesus told them plainly, "Lazarus is dead!" 15 I am glad that I wasn't there, because now you will have a chance to put your faith in me. Let's go to him."***

Notice this: John 11:20-22 (CEV) ***"When Martha heard that Jesus had arrived, she went out to meet him, but Mary stayed in the house. 21 Martha said to Jesus, "Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died. 22 Yet even now I know that God will do anything you ask."*** Jesus lets them know He will raise their brother to life and then proceeds to follow through on His promise. The point is, Mary and Martha thought their trial had come to do them in but Jesus revealed the real truth; their trial was going to take their faith to a new level!

Our responsibility in difficulty is to seek God's glory rather than our relief. Psalm 115:1 (CEV) ***"We don't deserve praise! The LORD alone deserves all of the praise, because of his love***

and faithfulness.” Psalm 106:7-8 (CEV) “When they were in Egypt, they paid no attention to your marvelous deeds or your wonderful love. And they turned against you at the Red Sea. 8 But you were true to your name, and you rescued them to prove how mighty you are.”

How then, did God take an impossible situation, flip it around, and use it for His honor? The story of parted waters shows us that God gains glory when:

- His enemies are defeated!
- His children are delivered!
- His name is exalted!
- His exploits are remembered!
- His praises are sounded!

Matthew Henry said, *"God sometimes raises difficulties in the way of His people, that He may have the glory of subduing them, and helping His people over them. The Lord devises ways of turning difficulties into deliverances and problems into praise. He gives beauty for ashes and an attitude of worship for the spirit of heaviness. He will glorify His name in the lives of His children, whatever their afflictions. He will gain honor for Himself over our adversarial situations. In the process, He will leave behind such blessings as make the burdens melt away like wax in the sunshine."*

Someone once said *“The sorest afflictions never appear intolerable, except when we see them in the wrong light.”*

A little gospel song of a hundred years ago simply say’s, *“In some way or other the Lord will provide. It might not be my way, it might not be thy way, and yet in His own way the Lord will provide.”*

With the same confidence we can say that in some way or other God will deliver His people from every trial and trouble they encounter. It might not be my way, it might not be your way, yet in His own way the Lord will deliver. He will do it for His own name's sake; He will do it for His own glory! Psalm 34:19 (CEV) ***“The LORD’s people may suffer a lot, but he will always bring them safely through.”***

In the events of the Red Sea the Lord intended from the beginning to gain glory for Himself by snatching His people from the jaws of annihilation at the last moment. He never worried about the outcome, knowing He could provide an escape route at any time! 1 Corinthians 10:13 (CEV) ***“You are tempted in the same way that everyone else is tempted. But God can be trusted not to let you be tempted too much, and he will show you how to escape from your temptations.”***

I will be the first to admit that the Lord doesn't always deliver us from our problems in the way we want Him to. He does it His way, but in the long run His way is always best, and it always leads to God's glory! Psalm 50:15 (CEV) ***“Pray to me in time of trouble. I will rescue you, and you will honor me.”***

III. STRATEGY #3: ACKNOWLEDGE YOUR ENEMY, BUT KEEP YOUR EYES ON THE LORD!

There is no question that Israel had an enemy. The design of the enemy is consistently bent on destruction and demise.

Look at what Israel was facing. Exodus 14:5-9 (CEV) ***“When the king of Egypt heard that the Israelites had finally left, he and his officials changed their minds and said, “Look what we have done! We let them get away, and they will no longer be***

our slaves.”6 The king got his war chariot and army ready. 7 He commanded his officers in charge of his six hundred best chariots and all his other chariots to start after the Israelites. 8 The LORD made the king so stubborn that he went after them, even though the Israelites proudly went on their way.”

The Israelites could have denied the existence of an enemy but that would not have changed the fact that a hostile king was in hot pursuit of this group of emancipated slaves.

The denial of an enemy never calms his hostilities but the acknowledgement of his existence demands readiness. Charles Spurgeon paraphrases this Scripture in this way, *“The great tyrant has not forgotten you, and he designs your capture and re-enslavement.”*

The devil sometimes launches direct, frontal attacks against us. But Satan is usually more conniving and insidious. In Ephesians 6:12-13 (CEV) ***“We are not fighting against humans. We are fighting against forces and authorities and against rulers of darkness and powers in the spiritual world. 13 So put on all the armor that God gives. Then when that evil day comes, you will be able to defend yourself. And when the battle is over, you will still be standing firm.”***

Whenever the enemy attacks, whether covertly or overtly, he is normally closer and cruder than we first imagined, much like the Pharaoh of the Exodus.

Have you ever felt pursued? Oppressed? Sensed the devil nipping at your heels? Ever wondered if your simultaneous troubles were orchestrated by a brutal, invisible hand? Suspected that your depression or anger stemmed from a malicious source?

While dealing with difficulty we should always acknowledge our enemy, while keeping our eyes on the Lord.

I want us to consider the parallels between Pharaoh and Satan:

- Both are unyielding enemies!

- Both covet power over their subjects!
- Both are enraged beyond reason!
- Both have assembled vast armies meant for destruction!
- Both will eventually be plundered by the Almighty!

The Bible likens Satan to five different animals:

- In Genesis 3, he's a serpent trying to deceive God's people!
- In Matthew 13, he's a bird trying to defile God's harvest!
- In John 10, He's a wolf attacking God's flock!
- In First Peter, he's a lion trying to devour God's children!
- In Revelation 12, he's a dragon wanting to destroy God's Son!

There is little question with regard to the intentions of our enemy. He is viewed as malicious, malignant and venomous.

This is not the kind of enemy we can defeat simply with the denial of his presence.

So how do we overcome him? The blood of Jesus Christ forgives our sins and resolves our guilt. His resurrection frees us from the fear of death, and it satisfies our need for eternal significance and happiness. The presence of the Lord surrounds us, while the promises of the Bible sustain us. His grace heals our whip wounds. Jesus said, "Therefore if the Son makes you free, you shall be free indeed" (John 8:36).

This enemy doesn't surrender his prey without a fight. He comes racing after us, chariot wheels churning the dust, seeking to discourage us, to defeat us. He pursues us with the intensity of Pharaoh.

He may use:

- Our own friends!

- The weapon of persecution!
- The weapon of discouragement!
- Family members!
- A hypocrite in the church!
- An onslaught of temptation!
- A barrage of troubles and trials!

We can be assured; our enemy will attempt to trap us in our troubles; entangle us in our dilemmas; corner us in an impossible situation; or lure us into temptation.

If you're in a tough situation right-now suffering pain, worry, anguish, or illness, you can rest assured the devil is undoubtedly behind it. John 10:10 (CEV) ***"The thief comes only to rob, kill, and destroy. I came so that everyone would have life, and have it in its fullest."***

We should acknowledge Satan's activity but we are not intimidated by him. We can resist him in the power of God and by the blood of Jesus Christ. In fact, our Commander in chief enjoins us to such resistance. When threatened by the devils schemes, we should stand on the Word.

Daniel 11:32 (CEV) ***"The king will use deceit to win followers from those who are unfaithful to God, but those who remain faithful will do everything possible to oppose him."***

James 4:7-8 (CEV) ***"Surrender to God! Resist the devil, and he will run from you. 8 Come near to God, and he will come near to you. Clean up your lives, you sinners. Purify your hearts, you people who can't make up your mind."***

1 Peter 5:9 (CEV) ***"But you must resist the devil and stay strong in your faith. You know that all over the world the Lord's followers are suffering just as you are."***

We our effort to resist the enemy we should employ every weapon and piece of armor which has been made available to us. 2 Corinthians 10:3-6 (NKJV) ***"For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh.4 For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal but mighty in God for pulling***

down strongholds,⁵ casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ,⁶ and being ready to punish all disobedience when your obedience is fulfilled.”

Ephesians 6:10-19 (NKJV) *“Finally, my brethren, be strong in the Lord and in the power of His might.¹¹ Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil.¹² For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places.¹³ Therefore take up the whole armor of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand.¹⁴ Stand therefore, having girded your waist with truth, having put on the breastplate of righteousness,¹⁵ and having shod your feet with the preparation of the gospel of peace;¹⁶ above all, taking the shield of faith with which you will be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked one.¹⁷ And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God;¹⁸ praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, being watchful to this end with all perseverance and supplication for all the saints—¹⁹ and for me, that utterance may be given to me, that I may open my mouth boldly to make known the mystery of the gospel,”*

We should resist the enemy in the name of Jesus Christ! We should stand our ground! We should shake off discouragement! When we do this the enemy is doomed to be drowned in the Red Sea of the blood of Jesus Christ.

Every time we resist the slightest temptation, we honor God. Every time we overcome even the smallest problem by trusting and obeying our Lord Jesus, God is glorified in our lives.

We should always choose:

- Character over convenience!

- Faithfulness over ease!
- Honesty over deceit!

Do we have an enemy? Yes! Will we experience problems? Yes! Will we be defeated? No!

Look at the patriarch Job and how he faced his difficulties courageously! In one terrible season:

- He lost his herds to barbarians!
- He lost his children to a tornado!
- He lost his health to a disease!
- He lost his wealth to misfortune!
- He lost his friends to a critical spirit!
- He lost his wife to doubt!

As he sat among the ashes scraping his boils with pottery shards and bemoaning his fate, he didn't realize that his afflictions had been orchestrated by Satan in an attempt to destroy his soul. This was nonetheless a fact!

Job emerged on the other side of the trial with his faith intact and his attitude optimistic!

The same devil orchestrates similar attacks against us today. How do we respond? We draw near to Christ and keep ourselves under the protective cloud of His grace. In Exodus 14, Pharaoh could threaten with brute force and protest; he could stir up frightening clouds of chariot dust; he could terrify with a thousand swords. But he was powerless to actually harm the Israelites as long as they remained under the protective cloud of God's glory and grace.

The same is true of us! As long as we walk in His will there is nothing that hell can devise which will be successful against us! Isaiah 54:17 (NKJV) **"No weapon formed against you shall prosper, And every tongue which rises against you in judgment You shall condemn. This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD, And their righteousness is from Me," Says the LORD.**

We must acknowledge our enemy while keeping our eyes on the Lord. The mistake we often make is we acknowledge the Lord while keeping our eyes on our enemy!

For all his insights and explanations about the evil one, the apostle Paul, in reality, focused on Christ. In the Pauline letters:

- The word *Jesus* occurs in 219 verses!
- The word *Lord* in 272 verses!
- The word *Christ* in 389 verses!
- The word Satan in only 10 verses, and the word *devil* in only 6!

When things are going badly, when we feel trapped between the sword and the sea, when we are under assault, we must acknowledge the enemy but keep our eyes on Christ! He will see us through! He will make a way!

IV. STRATEGY #4: PRAY!

Exodus 14:10 (NKJV) “*And when Pharaoh drew near, the children of Israel lifted their eyes, and behold, the Egyptians marched after them. So they were very afraid, and the children of Israel cried out to the LORD.*”

The children of Israel were in a hopeless situation as far as the arm of flesh is concerned.

(PLACE MAP ON THE SCREEN)

The mountains and the sea fenced them in with the only route for escape in the direction of the Egyptian troops with their chariot wheels rumbling and horses hooves churning up dust. Matthew Henry said, “*Their fear set them a praying, and that was a good effect of it. God brings us into straits that He may bring us to our knees.*”

All of us are bound to encounter circumstances that tend to cause us to choose between panic and prayer. Most of us have a propensity to panic before we pray. I must admit that I have had my share of hyperventilating, heart-racing, panic attacks. Panic is never the answer, prayer is always the answer!

The Lord desires us to know that prayer is the means by which I can stay even-tempered, self-possessed, cool-headed and strong-spirited even in the midst of a crisis!

When we can't press forward, move sideward, or step backward, it's time to look upward and ask God to make a way where there seems to be no way. (TAKE MAP DOWN)

In a time of uncertainty, the patriarch Jacob said, Genesis 35:3 (NKJV) ***“Then let us arise and go up to Bethel; and I will make an altar there to God, who answered me in the day of my distress and has been with me in the way which I have gone.”***

Referring to his days as a fugitive, David wrote, 2 Samuel 22:7 (NKJV) ***“In my distress I called upon the LORD, And cried out to my God; He heard my voice from His temple, And my cry entered His ears.”***

Psalms 107:25-29 (NKJV) ***“For He commands and raises the stormy wind, which lifts up the waves of the sea. 26 They mount up to the heavens, they go down again to the depths; their soul melts because of trouble. 27 They reel to and fro, and stagger like a drunken man, And are at their wits’ end. Then they cry out to the LORD in their trouble, And He brings them out of their distresses. 29 He calms the storm, So that its waves are still.”***

That's just what happened as the Israelites cried out to God at the Red Sea, except there the waves became trembling walls of water, held back by invisible hands. It takes a little faith to go into a sea whose walls are apparently held back by an east wind! I am not so sure that the Israelites went into the sea because of their faith in God as much as their fear of Pharaoh.

Daily devotions and crisis time prayer vigils are worlds apart! Crisis time prayers are prayers of importunity and intensity. Prayers during life-threatening or soul-shattering events tend to be passionate appeals to a God who is bigger and stronger than our own abilities. In a time of crisis we are brought to a place

where we not only realize but actually acknowledge Gods ability and our inability! Matthew 17:21 (NKJV) ***“This kind does not go out except by prayer and fasting.”***

Ephesians 6:18 (NKJV) ***“Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, being watchful to this end with all perseverance and supplication for all the saints.”*** The Message Bible say’s ***“Pray hard and long,”***

The Israelites were in crisis in Exodus 14:10 (NKJV) ***“When Pharaoh drew near, the children of Israel lifted their eyes, and behold, the Egyptians marched after them. So they were very afraid, and the children of Israel cried out to the LORD.”*** Their seaside cry was sincere, genuine, heartfelt, urgent and united but unbelieving. The urgency of their prayer was obvious, evidenced by the verb ***“cried”***.

Cameron Thompson, in his booklet, *“Master Secrets of Prayer”* makes the following statement, *“There comes a time, in spite of our soft, modern ways, when we must be desperate in prayer, when we must wrestle, when we must be outspoken, shameless and importunate.”*

Many of the prayers recorded in Scripture are just that, desperate cries! The Hebrew and Greek words are very strong with regard to desperate prayer. James 5:16 (NKJV) ***“Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The effective, fervent prayer of a righteous man avails much.”*** This literally means that the producing, valid, intensely earnest prayer of a righteous person will get the job done.

I recall times in my own life when my prayer was a prayer of desperation:

- When I was four, my dad was almost killed in a logging accident...
- When Jason was three, he was healed of a severe ear infection...
- When I have experienced a crisis in the church...

Sometimes crisis prayers are prolonged; I have actually prayed all night a time or two! I have fasted three days; ten days; twenty one days; twenty eight days; and thirty days. You don't take such measures unless you are desperate!

Other times, however, my prayers are quite short:

- When I am tempted to lose my temper, *"Make me sweet Lord"* seems to work!
- When I encounter a person I do not like very much, *"Grant me your love Lord"* seems to work!
- When I am tempted to dress someone down with my words, *"Let me speak your words Lord"* seems to work!
- When I am dealing with a situation I do not know how to handle, *"Give me your wisdom and understanding Lord"* seems to work!

The length of the prayer is inconsequential; the authenticity, intensity and earnestness of the prayer are what God is considering!

Looking back over the years, I've never faced a crisis in which, in response to earnest prayer, whether prolonged or instant, God didn't make a way.

The difference between those who know the Lord and those who do not know Him is that we have placed our trust in one who can part the Sea!

Crisis praying often happens in the solitude of our own pain but as is in the case of Israel at the Red Sea it can also be a corporate petition! Exodus 14:10 (NKJV) ***"When Pharaoh drew near, the children of Israel lifted their eyes, and behold, the Egyptians marched after them. So they were very afraid, and the children of Israel cried out to the LORD."*** There was one great united cry, rising from a host of voices, piercing the heavens like an amalgamated, massive signal of distress shouting to God, ***"HELP US!"*** Have you ever been there? About all you could get out was ***"HELP US!"***

The Israelites' prayer was not only united, but also earnest and sincere! They had never been more earnest! This prayer was far

more than a religious ritual, they were panic stricken and their outburst of prayer was real and unrefined.

Listen to the way the men and women of the Bible prayed, and compare it to our prayer life:

- Elijah prayed concerning the sinful condition of his nation. James 5:17-18 (NKJV) ***“Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed earnestly that it would not rain; and it did not rain on the land for three years and six months.18 And he prayed again, and the heaven gave rain, and the earth produced its fruit.”***
- Job prayed concerning his distressful situation. Job 8:5-7 (NKJV) ***“If you would earnestly seek God And make your supplication to the Almighty, 6 If you were pure and upright, Surely now He would awake for you, and prosper your rightful dwelling place 7 Though your beginning was small, Yet your latter end would increase abundantly.”***
- Jairus pleaded for his daughter’s life. Mark 5:22-23 (NKJV) ***“And behold, one of the rulers of the synagogue came, Jairus by name. And when he saw Him, he fell at His feet23 and begged Him earnestly, saying, “My little daughter lies at the point of death. Come and lay Your hands on her, that she may be healed, and she will live.”***
- Jesus pleaded His case to the Father in the Garden of Gethsemane. Luke 22:42 (NKJV) ***“Father, if it is Your will, take this cup away from Me; nevertheless not My will, but Yours, be done.”*** Luke 22:44 (NKJV) ***“And being in agony, He prayed more earnestly. Then His sweat became like great drops of blood falling down to the ground.”***

We are admonished to pray passionately concerning our needs and the needs of others. Colossians 4:2 (NKJV) ***“Continue earnestly in prayer, being vigilant in it with thanksgiving.”***

When God, in His grace and mercy, answered the cry of the Israelites alongside the sea, it wasn't because they expected Him to. Look at the way the passage unfolds. Exodus 14:10-11 (NKJV) ***“And when Pharaoh drew near, the children of Israel lifted their eyes, and behold, the Egyptians marched after them. So they were very afraid, and the children of Israel cried out to the LORD.¹¹ Then they said to Moses, “Because there were no graves in Egypt, have you taken us away to die in the wilderness? Why have you so dealt with us, to bring us up out of Egypt?”***

They prayed, but they didn't imagine God would actually answer their prayer. Their prayers were not mixed with faith.

Sad to say, we have all known moments like this. We prayed but did not expect results because the situation seemed too far out of hand. God desires for us to pray while having faith in Him and His ability to reverse the situation. Mark 11:22-24 (NKJV) ***“So Jesus answered and said to them, “Have faith in God.²³ “For assuredly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, ‘Be removed and be cast into the sea,’ and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that those things he says will be done, he will have whatever he says.²⁴ “Therefore I say to you, whatever things you ask when you pray, believe that you receive them, and you will have them.”***

Thomas Watson, the Puritan writer, said, *“Faith is to prayer what the feather is to the arrow; it feathers the arrow of prayer, and makes it fly swifter, and pierce the throne of grace.”*

When we face impossible odds, we should pray passionately but our prayers should be faith filled because the God we serve is bigger than our problems. If he can dry out a Red Sea for a group of Old Testament emancipated slaves He can surely solve the problems of New Testament covenant dwellers! Because of this we

will trust the great prayer-answering God who grants mercy and imparts grace to help in time of need.

V. STRATEGY # 5: STAY CALM AND CONFIDENT, GIVE GOD TIME TO WORK!

Israel was not very good at staying neither calm nor remaining confident in the time of crisis! Exodus 14:10-12 (NLT) ***“As Pharaoh and his army approached, the people of Israel could see them in the distance, marching toward them. The people began to panic, and they cried out to the LORD for help. 11 Then they turned against Moses and complained, ‘Why did you bring us out here to die in the wilderness? Weren’t there enough graves for us in Egypt? Why did you make us leave? 12 Didn’t we tell you to leave us alone while we were still in Egypt? Our Egyptian slavery was far better than dying out here in the wilderness!’”***

Amid all the murmuring, complaining and personal attacks Moses never flinched! He kept his head high, his face confident and never let his lip quiver. He got a deep seat and a far away look! Listen to how he responds. Exodus 14:13-14 (NKJV) ***“And Moses said to the people, ‘Do not be afraid. Stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD, which He will accomplish for you today. For the Egyptians whom you see today, you shall see again no more forever.’ 14 ‘The LORD will fight for you, and you shall hold your peace.’”***

J. Hudson Taylor knew what Moses knew when he said, *“I am waiting on thee, Lord, to open the way.”* The old song say’s *“Our Lord knows the way through the wilderness, all I have to do is follow.”* Oftentimes, the difficulty in following the Lord is running ahead of Him. Following the Lord requires patience and waiting! Someone said that they thought there would be some Pentecostals who would make Heaven, *“If they did not run completely past the gate!”*

The Lord delights in the impossible but He does not always do it when we think He should. Sometimes we must wait on Him to do His thing! (YOU HAVE NEED OF PATIENCE) (THEY THAT WAIT UPON THE LORD)

Moses told the Israelites: Exodus 14:13-14 (AMP.) ***"Fear not; stand still (firm, confident, undismayed) and see the salvation of the Lord which He will work for you today. For the Egyptians you have seen today you shall never see again. The Lord will fight for you, and you shall hold your peace and remain at rest"***

The biblical phrase ***"wait on the Lord"*** is the act of committing our Red Sea situations to Him in prayer, trusting Him, and waiting for Him to work. This is diametrically opposed to our proactive and assertive selves! Many a modern migraine would be cured by good dose of Psalm 37:7-8 (NLT) ***"Be still in the presence of the LORD, and wait patiently for him to act. Don't worry about evil people who prosper or fret about their wicked schemes. 8 Stop your anger! Turn from your rage! Do not envy others— it only leads to harm."***

When we face a difficult situation we need to entrust the problem to the Lord and leave it in His hands for as long as it takes. He alone can;

- Storm the impregnable...
- Plan the improbable...
- Perform the impossible...

He alone can part the waters! Matthew Henry said, *"In times of great difficulty and great expectation, it is our wisdom to keep our spirits calm, quiet, and sedate; for then we are in the best frame both to do our own work and to consider the work of God."*

The phrases *"fear not"* and *"do not be afraid"* are mentioned 107 times in the Old Testament, and 42 times in the New Testament. Anything mentioned so frequently in the Bible must be either a common condition among humans or a great priority with God. One thing is clear: God wants His children's emotions under control. We are emotional beings but our faith should be in control, not our emotions.

This is difficult for us. The very word emotion is the word motion with an "e" in front of it, I suppose this is for erratic!

Our feelings go up and down, sometimes with the velocity of a roller coaster. One moment we're enraged, the next moment we're consumed with love or lust or in the throes of depression or anxiety.

We have strong feelings which are often driven by compelling circumstances. Yet, everything is worsened when we give our emotions free rein.

That's the point of Exodus 14. The children of Israel had every reason to be terror stricken. They were cornered like rabbits by encircling wolves, and the dust in the distance raised up like thunder clouds that touched the horizon from ground to sky.

The Israelites were not only facing re-enslavement, but the impending slaughter of their families, their little ones, their aged parents as well as their flocks! They were about to lose it all! There was no hope of human escape!

Although there were good reasons to be afraid, there were even better reasons for remaining confident. They had an Ally alongside them who had sent lightning and locusts and a fistful of other plagues upon the Egyptians! Once He set them free from Egypt He placed a billowing cloud over their head by day and a fiery cloud by night! This cloud and fire was intended for several purposes:

- The cloud gave them shade by day!
- The fire gave them light by night!
- The cloud and the fire indicated where they were supposed to be!

The ally who pelted the Egyptians with pesky plagues and provided a cloud by day and a fire by night was saying; *“Get a grip on your emotions; remove your finger from the panic button; stop looking at the enemy and place your focus on your ally; He is going to fight this battle for you!”*

The same is true for us, we did not get here alone and the ally who brought us this far by faith will surely fight for us!

Dr. Martin Lloyd-Jones once preached a sermon on the terror of the disciples during the storm on Galilee. He ended with a sharp conclusion: *"I do not care what the circumstances may be, the Christian should never be agitated, the Christian should never be beside himself, the Christian should never be at his wit's end, should never be in a condition in which he has lost... It implies a lack of trust and confidence in Him."*

We must trust God with the impossible and leave room for Him to work, for the Lord has promised to fight for us. Search this out in Scripture, and you'll discover it's one of the truths the Lord most often repeats. Here are some examples:

- Deuteronomy 1:29-31 (NLT) ***"I said to you, 'Don't be afraid! 30 The LORD your God is going before you. He will fight for you, just as you saw him do in Egypt. 31 And you saw how the LORD your God cared for you again and again here in the wilderness, just as a father cares for his child. Now he has brought you to this place.'"***
- Deuteronomy 3:22 (NLT) ***"Do not be afraid of the nations there, for the LORD your God will fight for you."***
- Deuteronomy 31:6 (NLT) ***"Be strong and courageous! Do not be afraid of them! The LORD your God will go ahead of you. He will neither fail you nor forsake you."***
- 1 Samuel 17:47 (NLT) ***"And everyone will know that the LORD does not need weapons to rescue his people. It is his battle, not ours. The LORD will give you to us!"***
- Romans 8:31-37 (NLT) ***"What can we say about such wonderful things as these? If God is for us, who can ever be against us? 32 Since God did not spare even his own Son but gave him up for us all, won't God,***

who gave us Christ, also give us everything else? 33 Who dares accuse us whom God has chosen for his own? Will God? No! He is the one who has given us right standing with himself. 34 Who then will condemn us? Will Christ Jesus? No, for he is the one who died for us and was raised to life for us and is sitting at the place of highest honor next to God, pleading for us. 35 Can anything ever separate us from Christ's love? Does it mean he no longer loves us if we have trouble or calamity, or are persecuted, or are hungry or cold or in danger or threatened with death? 36 (Even the Scriptures say, "For your sake we are killed every day; we are being slaughtered like sheep.") 37 No, despite all these things, overwhelming victory is ours through Christ, who loved us."

When the Communists overran China following the end of World War II, a thousand missionaries with China Inland Mission (CIM) were trapped behind the Bamboo Curtain. CIM ordered a total evacuation in January 1951, but was it too late? . Arthur and Wilda Mathews applied for exit visas on January 3. Their living conditions had deteriorated to a bare kitchen where, in the corner, Wilda had converted a footlocker into a prayer nook. Days passed with no action on their requests. Meanwhile citizens were executed on the town's athletic field every day; from her kitchen Wilda heard the shots. The strain grew unbearable, and she was overwhelmed by fear. Sunday, March 21, 1951, was, as she later called it, Black Easter. Wilda sneaked into an Easter church service, but when she opened her mouth to sing "*He Lives!*" no words came out. Returning home, she fell at the trunk, and her trembling fingers found 2 Chronicles 20:15-17 "____." Wilda clamped onto those words, and two weeks later she wrote, "*The conflict has been terrible, but peace and quiet reign now.*" Over the next two years, the Mathews family repeatedly faced dangerous situations, their baby in harm's way, their pantry empty and their enemies surrounding them. Arthur and Wilda committed each situation, one after another, into the Lord's hands. Miraculously, in God's

timing, all the CIM missionaries got out without a single one being martyred, the last being Arthur Mathews. It was perhaps the greatest exodus since the one in Exodus 14!

Many times we cannot solve problems, heal hurts, change circumstances, or win our own battles. We must kneel in prayer, and then stand to see what He will do. We must leave room for God, staying calm and giving Him time to work.

C. H. Mackintosh said, *"Faith raises the soul above the difficulty, straight to God Himself, and enables one to stand still. We gain nothing by our restless and anxious efforts. ... It is therefore true wisdom, in all times of difficulty and perplexity, to stand still, to wait only upon God, and He will assuredly open a way for us."*

When you are going through a difficulty, stay calm and confident and give God time to work!

SONG: *"God will make a way."*

VI. STRATEGY #6: WHEN UNSURE, TAKE THE NEXT LOGICAL STEP BY FAITH...

Exodus 14:15 Exodus 14:15 (NKJV) ***"And the LORD said to Moses, "Why do you cry to Me? Tell the children of Israel to go forward."***

In our walk with the Lord there is a time when we must stand still and allow God to work but there are other times when we must take a step by faith. Missionary Isobel Kuhn said, *"I have found that if we go as far as we can, God often opens the rest of the way."*

On the despairing shores of the Red Sea, the Israelites couldn't see what was in the distance. They did not have the advantage of satellite imaging or even a set of binoculars that could view Canaan or even the opposite shore. But the Lord gave them a simple plan: **"...tell the children of Israel to go forward."**

The nineteenth-century expositor C. H. Mackintosh believed the Red Sea did not divide throughout all at once, but opened progressively as Israel moved forward, so that they needed to trust God for each fresh step. Mackintosh wrote, *"God never gives guidance for two steps at a time. I must take one step, and then I get light for the next. This keeps the heart in abiding dependence upon God."*

It is self-evident that God generally leads His children step-by-step, provides for us day by day, and cares for us moment by moment:

- Nehemiah 9:19 (NLT) ***"But in your great mercy you did not abandon them to die in the wilderness. The pillar of cloud still led them forward by day, and the pillar of fire showed them the way through the night."***
- Psalm 42:8 (NLT) ***"Through each day the LORD pours his unfailing love upon me, and through each night I sing his songs, praying to God who gives me life."***
- Psalm 110:3 (NLT) ***"In that day of battle, your people will serve you willingly. Arrayed in holy garments, your vigor will be renewed each day like the morning dew."***
- The Lord's Prayer gives us the following instructions:
Luke 11:3 (NLT) ***"Give us our food day by day."***
- 2 Corinthians 4:14-16 (NLT) ***"We know that the same God who raised our Lord Jesus will also raise us with Jesus and present us to himself along with you. 15 All of these things are for your benefit. And as God's grace brings more and more people to Christ, there will be great thanksgiving, and God will receive more and more glory. 16 That is why we never give up. Though our bodies are dying, our spirits are being renewed every day."***

Whenever I haven't known what to do, I've just tried to do what comes next, to take the next logical step by faith. I've decided that sometimes plodding is better than parking when it comes to finding God's will.

If in our pursuit of the will of God, our journey comes to a halt and we take the next step by faith in which direction should that step be taken? In the direction we were traveling when we last heard His word. The next step could be as simple as a phone call; writing a card; teaching a class; making a visit; or cutting up a credit card.

We can never be sure what will happen a year from now. But the next step is often more or less obvious.

- What direction has God been taking you all along?
- What would be the next step in the direction He has been taking you? Take the step even if by faith!

Dale Carnegie began his famous book *"How to Stop Worrying and Start Living,"* published in the 1940s, by describing a medical student who was profoundly anxious about the future—graduating from school, establishing a practice, making a living. He was working himself into a nervous breakdown. Then one spring day in 1871 he read twenty-one words from the writings of Thomas Carlyle that changed his thinking. The young man later became the most famous physician of his era. He organized the Johns Hopkins School of Medicine and became Regis Professor of Medicine at Oxford. He was knighted by the king of England, and he became the subject of numerous biographies. His name was Sir William Osier, and these are the words he read: *"Our main business is not to see what lies dimly at a distance, but to do what lies clearly at hand."*

Jesus taught us in the Sermon on the Mount: Matthew 6:34 (NLT) ***"So don't worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will bring its own worries. Today's trouble is enough for today."***

In Genesis 24, Abraham's servant Eliezer is on a mission to Mesopotamia to find a bride for Isaac. Arriving there, he met Rebekah and explained to her family his mission. Listen to what he says in Genesis 24:27 ***"Praise be to the LORD, the God of my master, Abraham," he said. "The LORD has been so kind and faithful to Abraham, for he has led me straight to my master's relatives."***

When we are not sure what to do next, fear often paralyses us rendering us incapable of making a good decision concerning the next step. We must cast fear out, and believe God for guidance in small increments. Oftentimes guidance in small increments amounts to the next logical step by faith!

When we are in a situation where we cannot perceive what lies dimly in the distance, we should do what lies clearly ahead. When we do this we should do it with confidence and faith! God always honors faith!

John Richie had this to say about Israel's trek through the Red Sea; *"It was a path where faith alone could walk, and step by step in faith they trod it until the other shore was reached."*

In 1 Samuel 9, Saul went looking for his father's lost donkeys, never dreaming the entire trip had been orchestrated by the Lord to lead the teenager to the prophet Samuel. When at last the two met, Samuel anointed Saul king over Israel and told him the donkeys had been found and that things would unfold for him like signs, step-by-step.

This was, in essence, the same plan God employed for the Israelites by the Red Sea. At the moment of their greatest perplexity, the Red Sea divided before them, and they took their first hesitant steps into the midst of the towering waters, timidly testing the sea floor and finding it a highway of hope, one that could be traveled step-by-step, moment by moment.

In the process they discovered the lesson later expressed by Daniel Whittle in his hymn entitled *"Moment by Moment"*: *"Never a trial that He is not there, Never a burden that He does not bear, Never a sorrow that He does not share, Moment by moment, we're under His care."*

Think of this:

- God created human beings to mature over a 70 year time frame.
- God created fruit trees, which reveal their fruit a little at a time.
- God created this earth which can only be viewed from one horizon to the next.

This same God guides our steps one footprint at a time! We must not doubt in the darkness what God has showed us in the light. We must not collapse when faced with adversity!

Following God's will is not a matter of unveiling, but unfolding!

The one who knows the faraway future reveals each close-at-hand-step as needed. A. T. Pierson said he prayed for twenty years, *"To go as I am led, to go when I am led, to go where I am led."* This is precisely what we are to do:

- To go as I am led...
- To go when I am led...
- To go where I am led...

In the same way the Israelites were called upon to approach the passage of the Red Sea, step by faith filled step, we are being called upon to move forward. Sometimes this is a moment by moment journey but we must keep moving forward by faith.

SONG: *"I'll go where you want me to go."*

VII. STRATEGY #7: ENVISION THE PRESENCE OF THE LORD...

Exodus 14:19-20 (NKJV) *“And the Angel of God, who went before the camp of Israel, moved and went behind them; and the pillar of cloud went from before them and stood behind them.²⁰ So it came between the camp of the Egyptians and the camp of Israel. Thus it was a cloud and darkness to the one, and it gave light by night to the other, so that the one did not come near the other all that night.”* The Israelites were assured of God’s presence as they went by faith into the sea, all that was required of them was to be aware of and follow the presence of God.

The presence of God would be a friend to the Israelites and a foe to the Egyptians. His presence would furnish light for the Israelites and would shroud the meticulous strategy of the Egyptians in disabling darkness.

God has committed Himself to fighting for the righteous! Our focus must be on remaining righteous under pressure! Romans 8:31 (NKJV) *“What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who can be against us?”* Remember, the word, if here means forasmuch as!

Notice where God is with regard to His people:

- He is above us and beneath us... His presence hovered over the Israelites in the form of a pillar of cloud and a pillar of fire. Isaiah 31:5 (NLT) *“The LORD Almighty will hover over Jerusalem as a bird hovers around its nest. He will defend and save the city; he will pass over it and rescue it.”* Deuteronomy 33:27 (NKJV) *“The eternal God is your refuge, and underneath are the everlasting arms; He will thrust out the enemy from before you, And will say, ‘Destroy!’”*
- He is before us and behind us... Isaiah 52:12 (NKJV) *“For you shall not go out with haste, Nor go by flight; For the LORD will go before you, And the God of Israel will be your rear guard.”*

- He is on the right hand and the left... 2 Corinthians 6:7 (NKJV) ***“By the word of truth, by the power of God, by the armor of righteousness on the right hand and on the left.”***

Amy Carmichael said, *“He is first, and He is last, and we are gathered up between, as in great arms of eternal loving-kindness.”*

God is has us surrounded! Psalms 139:5-6 (The Message) ***“I look behind me and you're there, then up ahead and you're there, too— your reassuring presence, coming and going. This is too much, too wonderful— I can't take it all in!”***

Psalms 125:2 (NKJV) ***“As the mountains surround Jerusalem, So the LORD surrounds His people From this time forth and forever.”***

Psalms 5:12 (NKJV) ***“For You, O LORD, will bless the righteous; With favor You will surround him as with a shield.”***

Psalms 32:7-10 (NKJV) ***“You are my hiding place; You shall preserve me from trouble; You shall surround me with songs of deliverance. Selah 8 I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will guide you with My eye. 9 Do not be like the horse or like the mule, Which have no understanding, Which must be harnessed with bit and bridle, Else they will not come near you. 10 Many sorrows shall be to the wicked; But he who trusts in the LORD, mercy shall surround him.”***

As a result, it should not be too difficult to envision His presence in the tough times.

Exodus 14 says the Angel of God went before the camp of Israel, then moved and went behind them. Who is this angel of God accompanying the Israelites in Exodus 14? When speaking to the Children of Israel concerning the slaying of the Passover lamb the previous chapter told us, Exodus 13:14 (NKJV) ***“So it shall be, when your son asks you in time to come, saying, ‘What is this?’ that you shall say to him, ‘By strength of hand***

the LORD brought us out of Egypt, out of the house of bondage.” The prophet Isaiah later said, Isaiah 63:9 (NKJV) ***“In all their affliction He was afflicted, And the Angel of His Presence saved them; In His love and in His pity He redeemed them; And He bore them and carried them All the days of old.”***

The pillar of fire and cloud, in theological language, was a Theophany or a Christophany. This is a singular Old Testament appearance of God Himself, specifically of God the Son, the second person of the Trinity, who manifests the Father's presence. John 1:18 (NKJV) ***“No one has seen God at any time. The only begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, He has declared Him.”***

The Lord Himself ushered the Israelites through the Red Sea! The Lord Himself has made a commitment to sticking with His people in difficult times! Hebrews 13:5 (NKJV) ***“...I will never leave you nor forsake you.”***

Notice the benefit of His presence. Exodus 14:19-20 (NKJV) ***“And the Angel of God, who went before the camp of Israel, moved and went behind them; and the pillar of cloud went from before them and stood behind them.20 So it came between the camp of the Egyptians and the camp of Israel. Thus it was a cloud and darkness to the one, and it gave light by night to the other, so that the one did not come near the other all that night.”*** What a perfect description of our Lord Jesus who gives light to those who trust Him; but to those who reject Him, utter darkness. He comforts the one and confounds the other. He is a Savior to the one, and a Judge to the other.

For His children:

- He guards us and guides us...
- He precedes us and protects us...
- He is simultaneously our shepherd and shield...
- He is Alpha and Omega...
- He is the first and the last...

- He is the one who goes before us and follows behind us...
- He guides us into the future and gathers up the debris of our past...

At the Red Sea, God placed His people in a position where they would have the opportunity to envision His presence in a new and improved way! He accomplished this by using difficulty! He cultivated within them a greater appreciation for Himself.

In the short term we prefer exemption or preemption. In the long term God's presence throughout the difficulty is much more productive.

When we find ourselves between the sword and sea, we must remember that difficult times can sensitize us to His nearness. He's never as close as when we're shipwrecked and driven by despair into His chambers where we find Him to be faithful! Psalm 46:1 (NKJV) ***"God is our refuge and strength, A very present help in trouble."***

In the midst of difficulty, God wants us to envision His enveloping presence, and learn to say, ***"I will fear no evil, for You are with me."*** This is especially important in dark valleys and hostile seas.

How can we master the practice of the presence of God?

- Affirm His nearness in our hearts... We should make sure we are in His will and once we do, we should stand on the Word! Philippians 4:5-6 (NKJV) **“Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God.”**
- Visualize His presence in our minds... Matthew 23:37 (NKJV) **“O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the one who kills the prophets and stones those who are sent to her! How often I wanted to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you were not willing!”** When we talk to God we should visualize Him sitting in the chair in front of us! When Dwight Moody was asked how he managed to remain so intimate in his relationship with Christ, he replied, *“There isn't any problem in my life, there isn't any uncertainty in my work but I turn and speak to Him as naturally as to someone in the same room, and I have done it these years because I can trust Jesus.”*
- Live life as if He is living it with us... We should live every day as if He is right beside us because He is! When Jacob was running from His brother, God spoke the following to him; Genesis 28:15 (NKJV) **“Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go, and will bring you back to this land; for I will not leave you until I have done what I have spoken to you.”**
- Reflect His presence in our demeanor... We should never allow fear to cloud our demeanor! 2 Timothy 1:7 (NKJV) **“For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.”**

The pillar of fire and cloud followed the Israelites through the wilderness then apparently disappeared when they entered the Promised Land! Right? Wrong! His presence was later seen in the spectacular clouds of glory that filled Solomon's temple, and again in the ball of fire that burst into the Upper Room on the

day of Pentecost. The same presence now resides in and around all Christians, everywhere, at every moment.

You are not facing your difficulty alone, for the Lord is closer than a friend or brother. Envision His enveloping presence right now.

SONG: “Surround me O’ Lord.”

VIII. STRATEGY #8: TRUST GOD TO DELIVER IN HIS OWN UNIQUE WAY...

Exodus 14:21-22 (NKJV) ***“Then Moses stretched out his hand over the sea; and the LORD caused the sea to go back by a strong east wind all that night, and made the sea into dry land, and the waters were divided.22 So the children of Israel went into the midst of the sea on the dry ground, and the waters were a wall to them on their right hand and on their left.”***

Who besides God would think to dry out a sea using a man with an outstretched hand and an east wind? I would have used an earth quake, drought or volcano but God uses the outstretched hand of a man and an east wind! B. H. Carroll said *“There came a mighty wind like a wedge and split that sea open, clear to its center.”*

The Israelites, held stationary and silent between the sea and the sword, watched in unbearable suspense as an old man by the name of Moses raised his rod over the imposing sea. An eastern wind suddenly began to howl from heaven dividing a sea the bottom of which had never before seen the light of day.

This wind began to batter tents and tenants as God set in place one of the greatest miracles of the Bible. The crowd who was privileged to witness this act of God was mostly skeptical people.

I am quite sure they watched in disbelief as the downdraft intensified, hit the water, and slowly plowed through the sea like a mighty turbo charged bulldozer.

The waves rose to unbelievable heights on the right hand and the left hand as God provided an avenue of escape for His people while setting a trap for the Egyptians. The sea would become a gateway to the one and a graveyard to the other,

This occurrence became the Old Testament's most dramatic object lesson. The lesson; trust God to deliver in His own unique way.

Deliverance is Gods specialty! Deuteronomy 23:14 (NKJV)

“For the LORD your God walks in the midst of your camp, to deliver you and give your enemies over to you; therefore your camp shall be holy, that He may see no unclean thing among you, and turn away from you.”

Psalm 34:19 (NLT) ***“The righteous face many troubles, but the LORD rescues them from each and every one.”***

2 Peter 2:9 (NLT) ***“So you see, the Lord knows how to rescue godly people from their trials, even while punishing the wicked right up until the day of judgment.”***

Psalm 50:15 (NLT) ***“Trust me in your times of trouble, and I will rescue you, and you will give me glory.”***

2 Timothy 4:18 (NLT) ***“The Lord will deliver me from every evil attack and will bring me safely to his heavenly Kingdom.”***

What does God deliver from?

- Sin...
- Habits and vices...
- Sickness and disease...
- Emotional difficulties...
- Relational stalemates...
- Financial problems...

God will deliver His children from every evil malicious work; from every peril and problem; from every trial and tribulation; even from death itself. While God is still in the miracle business we must remember, there is no such thing as a cookie cutter

miracle with God! He doesn't have standardized, same-size-fits-all solutions to our diverse problems. He treats every situation as singular and special, and He designs a unique, tailor-made deliverance to every trial and tribulation.

Cameron Thompson said, *"We have a God who begins with the impossible and goes on from there."* In Matthew 14 Jesus fed five thousand men plus women and children with five loaves and two fish, then retrieving twelve baskets of fragments. Another account has him feeding four thousand men plus women and children with seven loaves and a few fish, then retrieving seven baskets of fragments. If you extrapolate those figures:

- 7 Loaves feed 4,000, yielding 7 baskets...
- 6 Loaves feed 4,500, yielding 9 ½ baskets...
- 5 Loaves feed 5,000, yielding 12 baskets...
- 4 Loaves feed 5,500, yielding 14 ½ baskets...
- 3 Loaves feed 6,000, yielding 17 baskets...
- 2 Loaves feed 6,500, yielding 19 ½ baskets...
- 1 Loaf feeds 7,000, yielding 22 baskets...

What would He do if He had nothing? Nothing is exactly what He made the world of!

- God came from nowhere because there was nowhere to come from...
- God stood on nothing at creation because there was nothing to stand on...
- He reached out where there was nowhere to reach and hanged something upon nothing, spun the earth into orbit and told it to stay there and it stayed...

Christopher Knight and Alan Butler are two British researchers who are self proclaimed agnostics. They recently released a book called *"Who Built the Moon"* In this book they studied everything about the moon. They began with no religious prejudice, they just wanted to state every fact they could

discern by studying the moon. The following is a list of their conclusions:

- **Orbital Paths** - The Earth revolves 366 times in one orbit. The Sun and the Earth is 366% larger than the Moon. Conversely, the Moon takes 27.32 days to orbit the Earth and is 27.32% of Earth's size. In 366 orbits of the Moon, the Earth experiences 10,000 days.
- **Distances** - The Moon is 400 times closer to the Earth than the Sun and exactly 400 times smaller than the Sun.
- **Conformity to Metric System** - The metric system appears to have been created specifically to allow man to see more of the wonders of God. For example, the Earth is 109.3 times smaller than the Sun, while the circumference of the Moon when measured in kilometers is 10,930 km. Also, the Moon is turning at exactly 1% of the Earth's spin, which gives a speed at the lunar equator of precisely 400 kilometers per hour.
- **Conclusion** – *“There can be only one logical explanation for the precision of these relationships. Some agency saw the life bearing potential of the Earth/Sun system and added the Moon to create and nurture life. Where there should have been random, disconnected numbers there were beautifully harmonious relationships and repeating patterns. It struck us as though we were looking at some kind of engineering blueprint involving the Earth and the Moon's interaction around the Sun.”*

When we think of miracles we think of instances like the splitting of the Red Sea.

The Greek word for miracle is *dunamis* and means “*miraculous power or might.*” Harold Horton defines miracles in the following ways:

- *"A miracle is a supernatural act on the natural plane."*
- *"Works contrary to nature, accomplishments, so to speak, of the impossible, sudden and unaccountable reversals of the order to which we are accustomed."*
- *"A miracle is a supernatural intervention in the ordinary course of nature; a temporary suspension of the accustomed order; an interruption of the system of nature as we know it."*
- *"A miracle is a sovereign act of the Spirit of God irrespective of laws or systems."*

Based on Harold Horton's definition, we encounter miracles with more regularity than we might have envisioned. Throughout the Bible, God takes ordinary circumstances and turns them into miracles. The same is true today when His children encounter difficult circumstances, He shows up oftentimes in a subtle but big way! For the Christian, there is no such thing as luck or coincidence only the divine ordering of our steps!

God watches over His trusting children! His unseen hand is:

- Guiding his flock along...
- Guarding His people with His power...
- Arranging each detail with our best interest in mind...
- Rearranging circumstances to make sure everything turns out right...

In the unfolding of God's providence in our lives, His burdens become blessings, tears lead to triumph and the redemptive grace of God overcomes the undercurrents of life in the experiences of His children. For those of us who have decided to follow Him, ***"All things work together for good to those who love the Lord and are called according to His purposes."***

No wonder Charles Spurgeon once quipped, *"We believe in the providence of God, but we do not believe half enough in it."*

While we do believe in the providence of God, we have a most difficult time waiting for the promise! Hebrews 10:36 (KJV)

“For ye have need of patience, that, after ye have done the will of God, ye might receive the promise.” Vance Havner once said, *“God marks across some of our days, ‘Will explain later’.”*

God delivers in at least three distinct ways:

- Overtly – This is an unmistakable, undeniable miracle...
- Covertly – This occurs by providence or outside influence...
- Mysterially – This is a deeper level of intervention than our minds can discern. At this level of deliverance He has been at work behind the scenes arranging hundreds of details and schedules to bring about Mysterial intervention at just the right moment!

During the wilderness wandering of the Children of Israel God performed the miracle of provision so consistently that they assumed this was a normal way of life. When we read the story of Jehovah’s provision for the Children of Israel we take for granted the miracle of His provision! Look at the daily miracle of provision:

- The camp of Israel was two thirds the size of Rhode Island and covered 750 square miles...
- God provided approximately 4,000 tons of food per day...
- Transporting the food would require a freight train two miles long each day...
- The cost of the food would be approximately \$6,000,000.00 per day...
- An adequate water supply would equate to 11,000,000 gallons per day...
- The cost of water would be \$60,000.00 per day...
- Transporting the water would require a freight train 1,800 miles long each day...

God provided for them for 40 years or 14,600 days! This required:

- 58,400,000 tons of food at a cost of \$87,600,000,000...
- 160,600,000,000 gallons of water at a cost of \$876,000,000.00...
- Total cost of food and water would be \$88,476,000,000.00...
- Transportation for food and water would require a freight train 26,309,200 miles long and would reach around the world 106 times...

If we think about how many people God has provided for throughout the history of humankind we will begin to appreciate the miracle of daily provision!

Remember, in those instances where it appears God has lost the appointment of our deliverance in the shuffle of papers on His desk He is actually on the job working behind the scenes providing the components necessary for our miracle!

He has appointed for us something far greater than a miracle! Hebrews 11:32-40 (NLT) ***“Well, how much more do I need to say? It would take too long to recount the stories of the faith of Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, David, Samuel, and all the prophets. 33 By faith these people overthrew kingdoms, ruled with justice, and received what God had promised them. They shut the mouths of lions, 34 quenched the flames of fire, and escaped death by the edge of the sword. Their weakness was turned to strength. They became strong in battle and put whole armies to flight. 35 Women received their loved ones back again from death. But others trusted God and were tortured, preferring to die rather than turn from God and be free. They placed their hope in the resurrection to a better life. 36 Some were mocked, and their backs were cut open with whips. Others were chained in dungeons. 37 Some died by stoning, and some were sawed in half; others were killed with the sword. Some went about in skins of sheep and goats, hungry and oppressed and mistreated. 38 They were too good***

for this world. They wandered over deserts and mountains, hiding in caves and holes in the ground 39 *All of these people we have mentioned received God's approval because of their faith, yet none of them received all that God had promised.* 40 *For God had far better things in mind for us that would also benefit them, for they can't receive the prize at the end of the race until we finish the race.*" If we can just bring ourselves to trust in God, even though the going is a little tough, the end will turn out right for us, though for a time we may be perplexed.

In his last letter, the apostle Paul boasted, 2 Timothy 4:18 (NKJV) "***And the Lord will deliver me from every evil work and preserve me for His heavenly kingdom. To Him be glory forever and ever. Amen!***" Paul makes a statement of unwavering faith, yet he was beheaded days later, his body cast aside, and his head tossed into the grave after him. Did he miss it or have we missed something? We are so focused on our own relief that we often miss the greater good God has in mind for us!

Paul was:

- Snatched away from the evil that surrounded him...
- Removed from the tears that often filled his eyes...
- Freed from the pain of rejection inflicted upon him by his detractors...
- Healed from the pain of sickness...
- Relieved from the stress of life and ministry...

He was taken to a level where Satan could no longer harass him! At this level he would be in the presence of the Lord! Philippians 1:21 (NKJV) "***For to me, to live is Christ, and to die is gain.***" 2 Corinthians 5:6-8 (NKJV) "***So we are always confident, knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord.*** 7 ***For we walk by faith, not by sight.*** 8 ***We are confident, yes, well pleased rather to be absent from the body and to be present with the Lord.***"

After the loss of his wife, Vance Havner said, "*When before the throne we stand in Him complete, all the riddles that puzzle us*

here will fall into place and we shall know in fulfillment what we now believe in faith— that all things work together for good in His eternal purpose. No longer will we cry ‘My God, why?’ Instead, ‘alas’ will become ‘Alleluia,’ all question marks will be straightened into exclamation points, sorrow will change to singing, and pain will be lost in praise."

In the vortex of God's mysterious ways the words of Jesus become much clearer. John 13:7 (NKJV) ***“Jesus answered and said to him, “What I am doing you do not understand now, but you will know after this.”***

You can well trust Him to save and deliver you from every evil work and preserve you for His heavenly kingdom. He will save and deliver in His own unique way, whether miraculous, providential, or mysterious. He always does that for His children. That's His specialty.

IX. STRATEGY #9: VIEW YOUR CURRENT CRISIS AS A FAITH BUILDER FOR THE FUTURE...

Exodus 14:30-31 (NKJV) ***“So the LORD saved Israel that day out of the hand of the Egyptians, and Israel saw the Egyptians dead on the seashore.³¹ Thus Israel saw the great work which the LORD had done in Egypt; so the people feared the LORD, and believed the LORD and His servant Moses.”***

J. Hudson Taylor said, *I know He tries me only to increase my faith.*”

We don't always know why God allows problems, but we know He intends to use them to heighten our maturity and deepen our faith. Difficulty is to the soul what physical exercise is to the body. We should view trials and troubles as dumbbells and treadmills for the soul. They develop strength and stamina.

Exodus 14 concludes by noting how the Israelites benefited from their narrow escape. It beefed up their faith for the great challenges ahead of them. Because of the challenge of the Red

Sea and the way God used His servants to bring resolution the Israelites ***"feared the LORD, and believed the LORD and His servant Moses."***

Faith has a cumulative quality to it. We amass and garner it. We grow it and lay it in store for future times. Our faith grows stronger through the seasons of life.

What exactly is faith? Not long ago in Fort Worth, a gunman walked into Wedgewood Baptist Church during a youth rally. Among those killed was fourteen-year-old Cassie Griffin. Interestingly enough, Cassie was a collector of frog paraphernalia; she collected frog figurines, frog trinkets, frog jewelry. According to her parents, the word *FROG* summarized her philosophy of life! *"Fully Rely On God."*

This is a wonderful definition of faith, *"fully rely on God!"*.

In Luke 1, when the Virgin Mary visited her relative Elizabeth and explained to her what the angel had revealed, Elizabeth makes the following statement. Luke 1:45 (NKJV) ***"Blessed is she who believed, for there will be a fulfillment of those things which were told her from the Lord."*** What a great expression of faith! Faith is simply *"Believing what the Lord has said to us will be accomplished."*

With regard to the faith of Abraham the writer of Hebrews said the following; Hebrews 11:11 (NIV) ***"By faith Abraham, even though he was past age—and Sarah herself was barren— was enabled to become a father because he considered him faithful who had made the promise."*** In Romans 4:20-21 (NLT), the apostle Paul wrote, ***"Abraham never wavered in believing God's promise. In fact, his faith grew stronger, and in this he brought glory to God. 21 He was absolutely convinced that God was able to do anything he promised."*** Abraham's definition of faith is *"Believing the maker of the promise to be faithful! Being fully persuaded that God has the power to do what He has promised."*

In the violent storm in Acts 27:23-25 (NIV), the apostle Paul shouted over the tempest: ***"Last night an angel of the God whose I am and whom I serve stood beside me and said, 'Do not be afraid, Paul. You must stand trial before Caesar; and God has graciously given you the lives of all who sail with you.' So keep up your courage, men, for I have faith in God that it will happen just as he told me"*** Paul's definition of faith, *"believing that things will happen just as He has told me."*

When we connect the dots we discover faith is . . .

- *Believing that what the Lord has said to us will be accomplished...*
- *Believing the maker of the promise to be faithful...*
- *Being fully persuaded that God has the power to do what He has promised...*
- *Believing that things will happen just as He has told us.*

Every one of us live our lives by faith!

When we take our morning shower, we assume there's going to be water, preferably hot...

When we eat our cereal, we expect it to be healthy and wholesome...

When we drive to work, we proceed through green lights, assuming they are red for intersecting traffic...

When we step on the brake we expect the vehicle to stop...

When we press the accelerator we expect the vehicle to go...

Even the most sincere atheist lives by faith, not only in his atheistic philosophy, but in the very processes and procedures of everyday life. God created this universe so that the faith principle is always at work.

For Christians, faith is making certain assumptions about God's care and control over our lives, based on His scriptural promises. We may not understand every circumstance or appreciate every event. Sometimes we're backed up to the Red Sea with the Egyptians in pursuit. But God has given us promises, and we disappoint Him when we question His ability

to keep His Word. This is proven by the experience of the disciples on the Sea of Galilee. Mark 4:39-40 (NLT) ***“When he woke up, he rebuked the wind and said to the water, “Quiet down!” Suddenly the wind stopped, and there was a great calm. 40 And he asked them, “Why are you so afraid? Do you still not have faith in me?”***

Warren Wiersbe said, *"A faith that can't be tested can't be trusted."*

The level of faith differs from person to person! One person's faith is turbocharged while another's sputters on one cylinder. The reason for this discrepancy of faith is not that one person was given more than the other. In fact the Scripture tells us, everyone started out with the same amount of faith. (TO EVERY MAN WAS GIVEN THE MEASURE OF FAITH)

Several factors determine the level of our faith:

- The level of intimacy between the individual and the maker of the promise...
- The level of the practical knowledge of the Word of God...
- The amount of exercise our faith has received over the months and years...
- Our willingness to endure hardship without whimpering...

As Jesus wandered through Palestine, He had a sort of X-ray vision that penetrated hearts and measured faith. He seemed intensely interested in the quantity of faith being exercised by those who crossed His path. He made various statements with regard to those whom he met:

The Centurion of Capernaum whose servant was at the point of death told Jesus He did not need to come to his house to heal his servant. He said ***“Just speak the word and he will be healed.”*** Jesus said, Matthew 8:10 (NLT) ***“I tell you the truth, I haven’t seen faith like this in all the land of Israel!”***

The Canaanite woman whose daughter was demon possessed would not take no for an answer said ***“Even the dogs get crumbs from the Masters table!”*** Jesus said, Matthew 15:28 ***“Woman, your faith is great. Your request is granted.”***

To the Disciples on the Sea of Galilee He said, ***“Why are you so afraid? Do you still not have faith in me?”*** Matthew 8:26 (NLT)

Several Friends brought a paralyzed man to Jesus in Matthew 9:2 (NLT) ***“Seeing their faith, Jesus said to the paralyzed man, “Take heart, son! Your sins are forgiven.””***

Without question, it takes faith to move the hand of God and when He sees our faith He rewards those who fully trust Him. Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV) ***“But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.”***

Faith isn't something I can muster up at will; it must be given by God and developed according to the processes of life which He has ordained. He is, after all, a God who grows things. Physically, each of us began life as a tiny speck. It's a marvelous cell, for all the characteristics of each person; the sex, eye color, shoe size, intelligence, and so forth are determined at fertilization by the baby's genetic code that resides in the forty-six human chromosomes in that one cell.

We begin microscopically, and then grow into a mature human being. In the same way faith begins small and grows mighty! God intends to develop us spiritually. How? Like any good teacher, He bestows truth; then devises tests to review and reinforce that truth, to transfer and translate it into lasting, life changing experiences.

Like any good coach, He sits down with His players, using a game book of Scripture, gives us information, explains the rules, and reviews the plays. Then comes the scrimmage; the video tapes; the correction; more information and another scrimmage. It is virtually an endless cycle.

In the process:

- Good players become skilled professionals...
- Good people become growing disciples...
- Little faith grows into great faith...
- Mountains become molehills...
- Difficulties become opportunities...

This process is how God chose to deal with the Children of Israel and with the disciples. With the Israelites, He gave instructions through Moses, then brought them to the edge of the Red Sea. He provided a miracle in the Red Sea passage then led them to Canaan. Because of their unbelief He led them from Canaan to the wilderness where He allowed them to be tested. The wilderness is the place where the Children of Israel were permitted to apply their promises to their problems.

Jesus taught the disciples on the mountainside, then loaded them into a boat and sent them into a terrific storm designed to help them apply the promise to the problem.

The same is true for us. At church we hear the Word of God, and in our devotions we feed on the Scriptures. The Lord then sends a trial into our lives to give us an opportunity to put His teachings into practice. As we trust Him and pass the test, we're strengthened for the future.

This, then, is the principle: our faith grows when we choose to apply God's promises to today's problems and use the experiences to mature us for tomorrow's challenges. In a sense, we are storing up faith for times ahead. That's why the Bible is so full of promises. We never encounter any situation for which God has not provided a precious promise for our perplexing problem.

The Puritan Thomas Watson said, *"Faith lives in a promise, as the fish lives in the water. The promises are both comforting and quickening. The promises of God are flotation devices to keep us from sinking when we come to the waters of affliction!"*

J. I. Packer stated, *"In the days when the Bible was universally acknowledged in the churches as 'God's Word written,' it was clearly understood that the promises recorded in Scripture were the proper, God-given basis for all our life of faith, and that the way to strengthen ones faith was to focus it upon particular promises that spoke to one's condition."*

Faith, then, is simply finding and claiming the promises of God in every situation, and, based on those promises, making consistent decisions, being fully persuaded that God has the power to do what He has promised.

X. STRATEGY #10: DON'T FORGET TO PRAISE HIM.....

I want you to envision the Children of Israel at the Red Sea when the waters began to part!

At first there was dead silence. Picture this, a mute multitude gazing in stunned disbelief at a body of water whose powerful waves had only a few hours before been their worst nightmare now becomes a passageway to deliverance.

They traverse their difficulty on dry ground and look back on their greatest trial with disbelief. The terror was over; the enemy was gone; the night had ended successfully. Nothing was left but the stillness of a shocked people at daybreak. Finally someone breathed. Then came a whispering; then a buzzing; then the rumbling of three million emancipated slaves who are for the first time aware of the magnitude of the power of their God!

The volume must have sounded like a mighty tornado, as the ranges of emotions were finally released into the morning skies.

In a few minutes someone said, ***"I will sing to the LORD, for He has triumphed gloriously! The horse and its rider He has thrown into the sea!"*** Another rang out: ***"The LORD is my strength and song, and He has become my salvation."*** Another

sang: *"He is my God, and I will praise Him; My father's God, and I will exalt Him."* The floodgates of emotion broke, and the singing burst forth into the first recorded song in Scripture. Exodus 15:1-19 (NKJV) *"Then Moses and the children of Israel sang this song to the LORD, and spoke, saying: 1 "I will sing to the LORD, For He has triumphed gloriously! The horse and its rider He has thrown into the sea! 2 The LORD is my strength and song, And He has become my salvation; He is my God, and I will praise Him; My father's God, and I will exalt Him. 3 The LORD is a man of war; The LORD is His name. 4 Pharaoh's chariots and his army He has cast into the sea; His chosen captains also are drowned in the Red Sea. 5 The depths have covered them; They sank to the bottom like a stone. 6 "Your right hand, O LORD, has become glorious in power; Your right hand, O LORD, has dashed the enemy in pieces. 7 And in the greatness of Your excellence You have overthrown those who rose against You; You sent forth Your wrath; It consumed them like stubble. 8 And with the blast of Your nostrils The waters were gathered together; The floods stood upright like a heap; The depths congealed in the heart of the sea. 9 The enemy said, 'I will pursue, I will overtake, I will divide the spoil; My desire shall be satisfied on them. I will draw my sword, My hand shall destroy them.' 10 You blew with Your wind, The sea covered them; They sank like lead in the mighty waters. 11 "Who is like You, O LORD, among the gods? Who is like You, glorious in holiness, Fearful in praises, doing wonders? 12 You stretched out Your right hand; The earth swallowed them. 13 You in Your mercy have led forth The people whom You have redeemed; You have guided them in Your strength To Your holy habitation. 14 "The people will hear and be afraid; Sorrow will take hold of the inhabitants of Philistia. 15 Then the chiefs of Edom will be dismayed; The mighty men of Moab, Trembling will take hold of them; All the inhabitants of Canaan will melt away. 16 Fear and dread will fall on them; By the greatness of Your arm They will be as still as a stone, Till Your people pass over, O LORD, Till the people pass over Whom You have purchased. 17 You will bring them in and plant them In the mountain of Your inheritance, In the place, O LORD, which You have made*

For Your own dwelling, The sanctuary, O LORD, which Your hands have established. 18 “The LORD shall reign forever and ever.” 19 For the horses of Pharaoh went with his chariots and his horsemen into the sea, and the LORD rought back the waters of the sea upon them. But the children of Israel went on dry land in the midst of the sea.”

I can assure you that this glorious celebration in Exodus 15 was about as animated a gathering as any of us would ever attend. They did not set around on the sea shore and hold hands and sing cum by yah my Lord. There was no dim lights, thick curtains and soft music here! You find that kind of thing in a funeral home! This is anything but a funeral!

A nation of liberated slaves sang and danced and clapped and played their tambourines to frenzied exhaustion, the roar of countless voices echoing across the desert and through the skies all the way to heaven. Listen to this, Exodus 15:20-21 (NLT) ***“Then Miriam the prophet, Aaron’s sister, took a tambourine and led all the women in rhythm and dance. 21 And Miriam sang this song: “I will sing to the LORD, for he has triumphed gloriously; he has thrown both horse and rider into the sea.”***

We should be constantly prepared to praise God with reckless abandonment! Most of the time we are not ready or willing to do so! The reason; because we have not been in a difficult spot for so long that we have forgotten how thankful we are for His delivering power!

Maybe we need a crisis! One of the reasons God puts us in tough situations or allows us to be where we are is to give us the opportunity to sound forth His praises when He delivers out of our difficulties!

God expects our gratitude for His deliverances! Don’t forget to praise Him! Don’t be one of the nine lepers who never returned to give thanks, be the one who is grateful! If we return thanks we will be made whole! Give Him the glory!

In the seventeenth century, John Trapp wrote, *"He lets out His mercies to us for the rent of our praise, and is content that we may have the benefit of them so He may have the glory."*

In the history of the Christian church, some of our greatest hymns have come in the darkest moments: (HISTORY OF HYMNS)

We need to practice living lives which are more praise-oriented! Praise and worship are the sand and cement that hold the bricks in place along life's daily pathway.

Every segment of our day should be encased in praise.

- We arise each morning and begin our day with praise...
- We should live all day long in an attitude of praise...
- We should let His praise be revealed in all our conversations and relationships...
- We should end our day with praise to Him!

During our daily prayer times, instead of rattling off all our problems to the Lord like a grocery list, we should spend some serious time thanking Him for all the things He has done!

We should work on accentuating the positive and deemphasizing the negative! Remember every dark cloud has a silver lining! Charles Spurgeon said we should *"Wash our face every morning in a bath of praise."*

When we go to church we should concentrate on the God we are worshipping rather than the style of the worship service. If we are not careful, we will fall into the trap of worshipping worship! Worshipping worship looks like this:

- Only being able to worship during the music...
- Only being able to worship to a certain kind of music...
- Only being able to worship with a certain crowd...
- Only being able to receive from a certain preaching style...

I cannot imagine some sad-sack sitting on the banks of the Red Sea complaining because they sang a new song as opposed to an old one! (Story of couple who just started attending this church from a nominal background: they said “If a person could sit through the praise and worship in this church and not raise their hands and rejoice; something is bad, wrong!”)

The level of our rejoicing is directly tied to the nature of our involvement! If we have not been directly affected by the difficulty our praise and worship may not be as extreme as those who have been affected! (Randy & Joanna Lowe) (Sister Helms)

When we have been through the storm, we will be ready for celebration day!

2 Corinthians 2:14 (NLT) ***“But thanks be to God, who made us his captives and leads us along in Christ’s triumphal procession. Now wherever we go he uses us to tell others about the Lord and to spread the Good News like a sweet perfume.”***

Just as the battle is not ours but the Lord’s, the victory is the Lord’s as well! Because the victory is His we should celebrate each and every one of them! So whether you are on the upper side or the underside of the storm; whether you are on the east bank or the west bank of the Red Sea; God will make a way and when He does, don’t forget to praise Him!

The old song say’s:

- Praise Him in the morning...
- Praise Him in the noon time...
- Praise Him when the sun goes down...